

The Left Lens and the Right Lens

Each tribe has a canon within the canon. The verses we underline and the verses we explain away tell the truth about who is actually holding the pen.

THE SORTING

Two Canons, One Bible

Every Christian I know reads the whole Bible. Every Christian I know also has a working canon, the texts that get preached, quoted, and printed on signs, and the working canons sort neatly by party.

The conservative canon runs through Romans 13 on submission to governing authorities, the sexual ethics of Leviticus 18 and Romans 1 and 1 Corinthians 6, and the personal responsibility texts, 2 Thessalonians 3:10, if a man will not work, neither shall he eat. The progressive canon runs through Matthew 25 and the least of these, the Jubilee of Leviticus 25, Luke 4 and good news to the poor, and Amos rolling justice down like waters.

Set the two lists side by side and notice something uncomfortable. Both are Scripture. Neither tribe disputes the other's verses. We just file them differently. Ours are clear commands. Theirs are complicated, contextual, in need of careful handling by experts.

I had a working canon for years before I could see it. The verses I underlined and the verses I explained away mapped onto my politics with a precision that should have embarrassed me much sooner than it did.

THE MECHANISM

Lens First, Text Second

Here is the move both tribes make, and it is the same move. Lens first, text second.

Jonathan Haidt, no theologian, demonstrated it in the lab. Moral intuition comes first, and reasoning follows after, working not as a judge but as a press secretary. We feel our politics in the gut and send the mind out to find verses. The finding always succeeds. Scripture is a long book.

Mark Noll showed the same move at full historical scale. By 1861, devout Americans holding the same Bible and the same plain-sense hermeneutic split into two armies, each certain the text underwrote its

cause, and the dispute was settled not by exegesis but by artillery. Noll calls it a theological crisis because that is what it was: the Book could not arbitrate between readers who had already chosen. That should haunt every confident proof-texter in this country. It haunted almost no one.

The move is invisible from inside. No one experiences himself reading with a lens. We experience ourselves reading plainly while the other side twists. That symmetry, each tribe certain that only the other is captive, is itself the strongest evidence that both are.

THE RIGHT HAND

How the Right Reads Around

Watch the right handle the progressive canon. Matthew 25 gets narrowed: the least of these are Christian missionaries, so the passage is about church solidarity, not the poor as such. There is real scholarship behind that reading, but notice how eagerly the narrowing is received, how it arrives as relief rather than as loss. Jubilee becomes purely ceremonial, fulfilled in Christ, with no abiding word about debt or land or the concentration of wealth. The prophets thundering against those who trample the needy get filed under ancient Israel's covenant, not directly applicable, while the same prophets on idolatry and sexual sin remain timeless.

The technique is consistent. Spiritualize the text, contextualize the text, or kick the verse upstairs into the next life. By every route, the money stays where it was.

I was trained in this and I was good at it. I could exegete a hard saying of Jesus into something a major donor could live with, and I called the result balance. It was not balance. It was a tribe protecting its treasure from its own Scriptures, and I held the door open.

THE LEFT HAND

How the Left Reads Around

Now watch the left handle the conservative canon. Romans 13 gets historicized: Paul wrote to a vulnerable house church under particular circumstances, so the call to honor governing authority dissolves whenever the government in question is one we oppose, though it firms up again the moment our side holds power. The sexual ethics texts get assigned to ancient context, trajectory readings, what Paul could not have known. Some of those arguments deserve real engagement on exegetical grounds. But notice, again, how eagerly the conclusion is received, how the scholarship always lands exactly where the surrounding culture already stood. The personal responsibility texts fare worse. They are not reinterpreted. They are simply not preached.

The technique is the same one, run in reverse. Historicize the text, complicate the text, or kick the verse downstairs into the past. By every route, the autonomy stays where it was.

I have held this door too. There were years I softened what Scripture says about holiness because the room I wanted to reach found the subject embarrassing, and I called that compassion. Some of it was. Not all of it.

THE EXAMINATION

When Did a Text Last Change You

So here is the test, and I ask it of myself before I ask it of you. When did a passage of Scripture last change your politics? Not confirm them. Change them. Cost you a position, an alliance, an applause line. If the honest answer is never, then the Bible is not functioning as your authority. It is functioning as your wardrobe, and you dress your prior commitments in it every morning.

The correction is not a better lens. There is no lensless reading, and pretending to one is how we got here. The correction is a willing one: reading with your own tribe's canon set aside for a season, sitting under the verses your side explains away, asking God to make the text strange again. James Davison Hunter is right that Christians left and right have collapsed faith into political idiom until the church speaks nothing the culture has not already said. The way back is not centrism, which is just a third lens. It is submission, the old word, to the whole counsel of God.

I keep a list now of texts that have defeated me, verses that took something from me I wanted to keep. The list is short. It should be longer. The same is almost certainly true of yours.

KEY TEXTS

Romans 13:1-7

Matthew 25:31-46

Psalm 119:18

SOURCES

The Righteous Mind: Why Good People Are Divided by Politics and Religion — Jonathan Haidt

The Civil War as a Theological Crisis — Mark A. Noll

To Change the World: The Irony, Tragedy, and Possibility of Christianity in the Late Modern World — James Davison Hunter

The Bible in Politics: How to Read the Bible Politically — Richard Bauckham